

A V A R A I N V E S T M E N T S

The Systems Playbook

A Real-World Guide to Running a Small Business with AI

By Ryan Miller

Why This Exists

I bought a plumbing company. It had real revenue and almost no systems. Everything lived in one person's head.

I am not a developer. I had never really written a real line of real code for anything of use.

But in the first year of ownership, I built an entire operating system for the business using AI. Dashboards. Bots. Automated follow-up. Real-time numbers.

This ebook is the why behind all of it.

It is NOT a technical manual. It is NOT a list of tools. It is NOT a course.

It is the thinking. The reason we built each piece, and how the pieces fit together, so you can do the same in whatever business you run or buy.

You do not need to be technical. You need to decide your business deserves to run like a real company.

Let's get into it.

The Mindset

Most small businesses run on memory, hustle, and hope.

- The owner remembers who to call back.
- The owner checks the numbers when, and if, there is time.
- The owner is the system.

That is fragile. If the owner steps away, the business goes blind.

There is a better way. Build systems that do the remembering, the watching, and the reporting for you. The business should run whether you are there or not.

You do not need to know how to code.

- I describe what I want, in plain English, to an AI.
- It builds the thing.
- The real skill is not programming. It is knowing what your business actually needs.

The way I build is what people now call vibe coding. I describe what I want to Claude in plain English, it writes the actual code, I test it, I tell it what is wrong, and we go back and forth until it works. I am not typing code from scratch. I am directing it.

And you do not need it perfect. General Colin Powell had a rule for decisions. Move when you have 40 to 70 percent of the information. The same is true for building. Build it to 70 percent, put it to work, and improve it from there. Waiting for perfect is just a nicer word for never starting.

One more thing I learned buying a business. Build quietly on the backend. I changed software and added systems early, but I did the heavy lifting behind the scenes, tested it, and rolled it out clean. My team never felt the chaos. They just felt things getting easier.

It Runs on Rules, Not Magic

Here is the biggest misunderstanding about AI in a business. People picture an AI sitting in the middle, making every decision and pulling every string in real time.

That is not how I built this. And it is not how you should either.

Most of what runs my company runs on hard rules. Plain, boring, if-this-then-that logic that does the same thing every single time.

- If a call is missed, send this exact text.
- If an invoice hits thirty days, start this follow-up sequence.
- If a job's margin drops below the line, flag it.

That is the scaffolding. It is predictable, it is testable, and it runs the same way at 2am as it does at 2pm. No guessing, no drift.

The AI sits on top of that scaffolding, for the parts that need judgment. Reading a message, writing a reply, summarizing a week, grading a call, weighing two options.

Rules first. AI second.

This matters more than it sounds. You do not want a business where an AI is improvising your collections or your pricing live. You want the repeatable work locked onto rails, and the AI reserved for the parts that genuinely need a brain. That split is what makes the whole thing something you can trust to run without you watching it.

Three Ideas You Need (Explained Simply)

You will hear three terms over and over. Here is what they actually mean, without the jargon.

1. One Source of Truth

Your business data is scattered. Your phone system knows your calls. Your accounting knows your money. Your scheduling software knows your jobs. Your marketing knows your leads. Each one is an island.

The first job is to pull all of it into one place, so you can see the whole business at a glance. Everything else in this book is built on top of that one idea.

2. An API (your software's front door)

Every tool you use, your CRM, your accounting, your phone system, has a door it lets other software walk through to grab or hand off information. That door is called an API.

Connecting to that door is how I pull every job, invoice, and phone call into one place automatically, without anyone sitting there typing it in. The software talks to the other software. You just read the result.

3. An MCP (your AI's hands)

An MCP is what lets an AI reach into your tools and do things. Read your calendar, pull your numbers, send a message, update a record.

If the API is the front door, the MCP is the AI's hands that open it and get to work. It is the difference between an AI that just talks to you and an AI that runs tasks inside your business.

That is the whole foundation. Pull the data into one place with APIs, then let AI act on it with MCPs. Everything below is just that idea, applied.

The Systems, and Why We Built Each One

I group these the way I think about them. You do not need all of them. You need the thinking behind them.

Lead and Customer Systems

Missed-call text-back bot. The second we miss a call, the customer gets an automatic text. We missed your call, our team will be right back with you. Why: in home services a missed call is a job walking to your competitor. This keeps the lead warm long enough to win it. No new hire required.

Reply handler. When that customer texts back, the system acknowledges them and forwards the message to the team. Why: a fast first text is worthless if the follow-up drops. This closes the loop.

Callback tracker. It watches whether a missed call actually got a human callback, and how fast. Why: you cannot improve what you do not measure. Speed to lead is a number now, not a feeling.

Lead intake. Every lead, from the web, the phone, email, and ads, lands in one place, tagged with where it came from. Why: you cannot manage leads you cannot see, and you cannot judge marketing you cannot trace.

Accounts receivable automation. The system tracks every open invoice and follows up on its own, by email and text, until the money is in. Why: small businesses do not die from no sales. They die waiting to get paid. This does the uncomfortable part so cash keeps moving.

AR call list. Every Monday I get a prioritized list of the accounts most worth a personal call, with the phone numbers attached. Why: automation handles most of it, but the big or stubborn ones deserve a human, and I want to spend that time where it pays.

Money and CFO Systems

Automatic job costing. Every job gets costed automatically, so I know its real profit. Why: most owners find out a job lost money thirty days later. I know the same day. You cannot fix what you learn too late.

Job classification. Every job is sorted by type and department on its own. Why: "we did \$400k" means nothing until you know which kind of work made it. This tells me where the money actually comes from.

Monthly P&L by service line. The system maps the financials to the work and shows margin by department. Why: a single company-wide number hides the truth. This shows me which parts of the business to feed and which to fix.

13-week cash flow forecast. It pulls scheduled jobs, receivables, and payroll, and projects cash week by week. Why: cash flow is what kills good companies. Seeing a tight week coming gives me time to do something about it.

CFO-level data without a CFO. Job costs, margins, cash, and P&L, compiled every night. Why: I get the financial picture a six-figure hire would give me, without the seat. The system does the data. I make the calls.

QuickBooks sync. Bank balances, P&L, and receivables pulled automatically, twice a day. Why: real-time money beats a month-end surprise. The numbers are always current, never stale.

Operations and Visibility

The 7am morning brief. Yesterday's revenue, leads, calls, cash, and anything that needs attention, in one short summary every morning. Why: I run a company I bought with more visibility than owners who have had theirs for twenty years. No meeting. I just know.

The dashboard. One screen showing the whole business live. Revenue, leads, job costs, utilization, marketing, forecast. Why: scattered data is useless data. One screen is how a small shop out-decides a big one.

Call-grading bot. Every customer call is graded against a rubric we built. Discovery, objections, the booking. Why: most shops never listen to their calls. Now we coach the right things, to the right people, and the phone stopped being a black box.

Crew utilization. A daily breakdown of who is actually billable and who is not. Why: labor is the biggest cost in a trade. This shows me the truth instead of a gut feeling.

Integration health checks. Every morning the system confirms all the connections are alive, and texts me if one breaks. Why: a silent failure is the dangerous kind. I would rather know at 7am than find out from a missed week of data.

Data watchdog. Nightly, the system checks its own data for anomalies, like a sudden drop in jobs, and flags it. Why: bad data leads to bad decisions. This catches problems before I act on them.

Marketing and Growth

Attribution. The system traces a lead from its source all the way to the revenue it became. Why: "marketing is working" is not good enough. I want to know which channel actually made the money so I can spend more on that channel.

Weekly marketing ROI. Ad spend by channel, lined up against the revenue it produced. Why: this tells me what to cut and what to feed, with numbers instead of opinions.

Ad and SEO syncs. Google, Meta, and local search rankings pulled automatically. Why: you cannot manage what you cannot see weekly. This keeps the whole funnel in front of me.

Review monitoring. New reviews and rating changes tracked on their own. Why: reputation is a growth lever in home services. I want to know the moment it moves, especially if someone leaves a bad review. We need to get out in front of it as soon as possible.

The Build (How It All Holds Together)

The data syncs. Behind every system above is a quiet set of connections pulling from the phone system, the field-service software, accounting, the CRM, ads, and reviews into one place. Why: this is the one-source-of-truth idea made real. Nothing else works without it.

The AI layer (MCPs). On top of that data, AI can read, decide, and act, the hands I described earlier. Why: data that just sits there is a report. Data an AI can act on is an employee that never sleeps.

The assistant. I can ask plain-English questions and get answers, or have it write, summarize, and draft from the real business context. Why: the fastest way to a decision is to ask and get a real answer, not dig through five tools.

Documentation. Every system gets written down the day it is built. Why: a system nobody understands is a liability. Documented, it is an asset that outlives any one person, including me.

The Principles Behind All of It

- Put everything in one place first. No single system matters until the data is unified.
- Automate the uncomfortable. Follow-up, collections, asking for money. Let the system do the part people hate.
- Let the system do the watching. Your time is your scarcest asset. Spend it on decisions, not monitoring.
- Speed is a system, not a personality. You do not win on hustle. You win by building speed in once.
- Build quietly, roll out clean. Do the hard part on the backend so your team feels ease, not chaos.
- Start with one. One working system beats ten half-built ideas.

How to Start (You Do Not Need 41 Systems)

If I bought another business tomorrow, here are the first three I would build, in order.

- One dashboard or daily brief. Just see the business. You cannot run what you cannot see.
- Speed to lead. Never lose a lead to a slow response again.
- Real-time job costing. Know what makes money before you do more of it.

That is it to start. Get one running. Let it prove itself. Then build the next.

You will be tempted to build everything at once. Don't. The owner who ships one working system this month is miles ahead of the one with a perfect plan and nothing live.

How It's Actually Built (And What It Costs)

Let me get a little more specific, because the how matters.

I built almost all of this with Claude, using what people now call vibe coding. I describe what I want in plain English, Claude writes the actual code, I test it, I tell it what broke, and we go back and forth until it works. I am not a programmer typing from scratch. I am directing one that never gets tired and never forgets.

Underneath, the architecture is simple to say out loud.

- Hard-rule scaffolding, the automations that run on fixed, predictable logic.
- One data store, everything pulled into a single place through APIs.
- An AI layer (MCPs) that can read and act on that data.
- Claude on top, as both the tool I build with and the assistant I ask questions to.

Now the part people always ask about. The cost.

I run the \$200-a-month Claude Max plan. For a small business, that can sound like a heavy line item at first. Here is the honest math.

This replaced the work of several people.

- The reporting an analyst would pull.
- The follow-up a CSR would chase.
- The collections an office manager would work.
- The financial summaries a part-time CFO would prepare.
- The busywork I would have handed to one or two VAs.

Conservatively, that is multiple seats I never had to hire. Put \$200 a month next to the tens of thousands of dollars a year in salaries I did not add, plus the money saved by catching a bleeding job or a slow-paying account early, and it is not a close call.

\$200 a month is the highest-return line item in my business. It quietly does the work of a small team.

Forty-one systems. Built in months. Mostly by one person directing an AI. That is the part I want you to sit with. This is not out of reach for you. It is a decision and a tool away.

Conclusion: Freedom Is Built

I did not buy a business and inherit all of this. I built it, piece by piece, in plain English, with AI, while running the company.

The systems gave me three things. My time back, real visibility, and the confidence that the business does not live or die on me being everywhere at once.

That is the edge. Not a bigger crew. Not more hours. A business that runs like a real company, because you decided to build it that way.

You are not too late. You are not too technical. You just need to start with one.

Happy building. Your business is a lot closer to running itself than you think.

Your Next Step

You've got the why and the what. Now don't let it sit on your hard drive.

The owners who build systems and the ones who only read about them are separated by one thing. Starting. So before you close this out, take one small step today.

- **Build one this week.** Pick the first system from "How to Start." Don't build all of it. Ship one, watch it work, then build the next.
- **Thinking about buying a business, not just running one?** I wrote a companion guide, The Freedom Playbook, on how to actually buy a small business. Comment PLAYBOOK on any of my posts and I'll send it over.

You are a lot closer to a business that runs itself than you think. Let's build it.

— Ryan

P.S. If this helped, follow along on Instagram at **@ryanlmillerinvests**. That's where I share how I'm actually running a company with AI and systems, with no fluff. Come say hi and tell me what you're building.